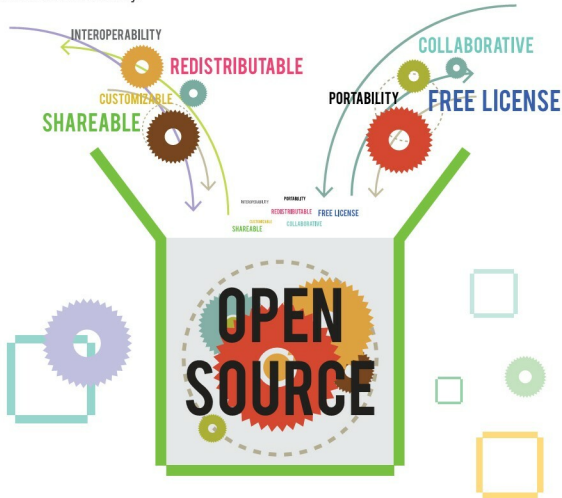


The Benefits of Open Source Products

According to OpenSource.org, “Open source software is software that can be freely used, changed and shared (in modified or unmodified form) by anyone. Open source software is made by many people, and distributed under licences that comply with the Open Source Definition.” Hence, the products built on open source software are low on cost and can be customised easily.



By open sourcing software, different people are able to come together and collaborate to improve it. Open source software (OSS) has been around for a while now. GNU/Linux kernel based operating systems like Ubuntu, Fedora, RHEL and Linux Mint are some good examples, while even the operating system on Android phones is Linux based.

From the business perspective, OSS offers many different benefits compared to proprietary software. With OSS, individuals or organisations do not have to pay for any software licences. If they are tech savvy enough, they can download, use and modify OSS, or else, they only pay for what the service providers charge to do the same. The important difference here is that the users are effectively

co-developers, who can suggest different improvements to the software, help in fixing bugs or even get into the source code and modify it according to their needs. All this might make the software even better, and benefit many others when it is shared.

Creating software and giving it away free isn't what open source is all about. Richard Stallman, the software freedom activist and founder of GNU, has said, “When we call software ‘free’, we mean that it respects the users’ essential freedom—the freedom to run it, to study and change it, and to redistribute copies with or without changes. This is a matter of freedom, not price, so think of ‘free speech’, not ‘free beer’. These freedoms are vitally important. They are essential, not just for the individual user’s sake, but for